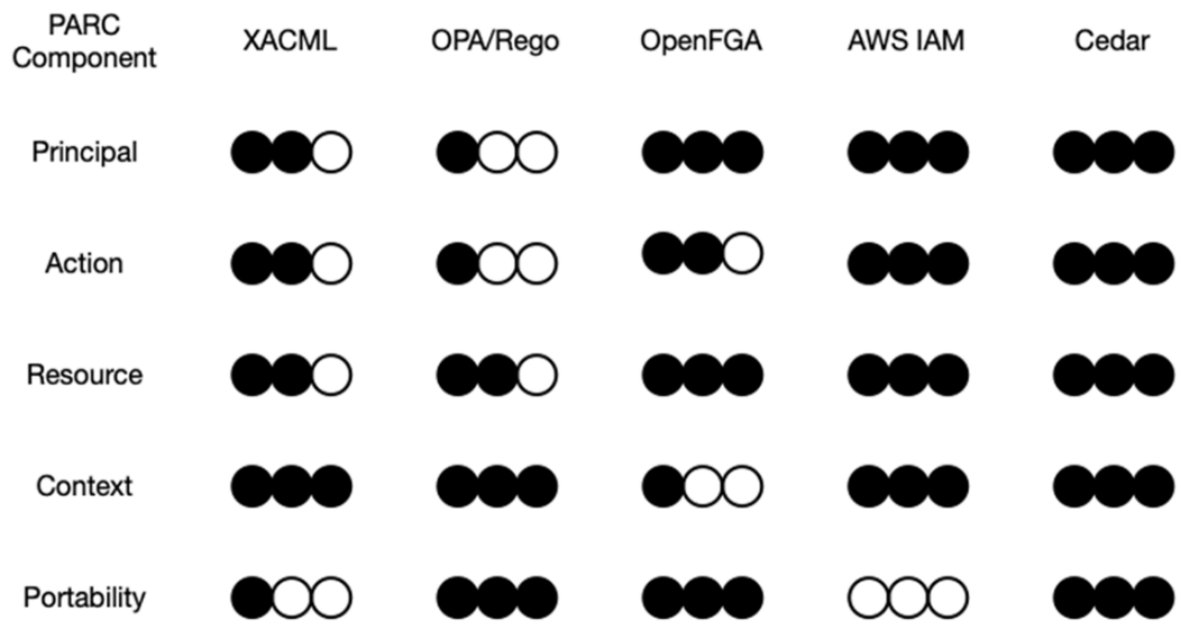


Figure 8.3 Strength map comparing five policy languages and frameworks—XACML, OPA/Rego, OpenFGA, AWS IAM, and Cedar—across the four PARC elements and portability. Darker shading indicates stronger, more native support for that element; lighter shading indicates partial or minimal support. This visual emphasizes how each system's design highlights different aspects of authorization, from attribute-rich context handling to typed principals and explicit resource modeling.

When choosing among these policy languages and frameworks, organizations should begin by identifying the types of authorization issues they most often need to address. Teams working in AWS will almost certainly use IAM for cloud access control but will probably require a different solution for authorization outside AWS. Applications that rely heavily on sharing and delegation might benefit from OpenFGA's relationship-based model, while systems that need precise, typed schemas and structural scoping could prefer Cedar. For cloud-native infrastructure spanning multiple platforms, OPA/Rego's flexibility makes it a strong choice. ALFA provides a way to use XACML without the hassle of writing policies in XML.

To narrow the field, ask:

- What's our primary model? Roles, attributes, relationships—or a combination?